



TIME TO RELAX AND RECHARGE | EXERCISE 3

Mindfulness and Meditation

Meditation offers significant benefits such as stress relief, increased attention span, better working memory and knowledge retention, better sleep quality, improved mental health, enhanced self-esteem, and greater resilience.

Mindfulness, one facet of meditation, reduces stress, anxiety, and depression by training focus on the present moment, leading to better emotional regulation, improved concentration, enhanced self-awareness, and better coping with difficult thoughts, as well as better sleep and potentially lower blood pressure. It enables you to observe thoughts without judgement, preventing negative cycles and fostering a calmer, more positive state of mind.



Technique 1: 5-Minute Body Scan

To reduce stress, improve body awareness and enhance relaxation

1. **Get comfortable:** In a quiet room either lie on your back or sit comfortably on a chair or cushion. Close your eyes and focus on your breathing – bring your attention to your natural breath -feel the air entering and leaving your nostrils or the rise and fall of your abdomen. If your mind drifts acknowledge the thought and guide your focus back to your breath.
2. **Feet:** Start by bringing your attention to your toes, focusing on any sensations.
3. **Legs & Hips:** Move awareness up to your ankles, calves, knees, and thighs, noting tension or heaviness.
4. **Torso & Back:** Focus on your hips, the rise and fall of your stomach, then your back.
5. **Arms & Hands:** Move to your fingers, hands, wrists, arms, and shoulders.
6. **Neck & Head:** Bring attention to your neck, throat, jaw, forehead and face, softening any tightness.
7. **Take a final deep breath,** feeling the whole body, and gently open your eyes. -If the mind wanders, gently return focus to the body part where you left off.

Benefit

This practice helps reduce stress, improves body awareness, and enhances relaxation. Many people experience a shift towards calm and balance in both body and mind through measurable physiological changes, increased awareness of the body's internal state and strengthened emotional regulation.

This occurs through:

- Activation of the parasympathetic nervous system causing the body to shift from stress mode to a relaxed state.
- Lowering of cortisol levels, the main stress hormone.